

A New Era of Obesity Treatments

Key words and phrases from the *New Scientist* article · Level C

The words and phrases below appear in the article *A New Era of Obesity Treatments* by Clare Wilson, published in *New Scientist* (30 December 2023). The vocabulary spans three registers: pharmacology and clinical medicine, healthcare economics and access, and journalistic and descriptive language. Study the table carefully before attempting the gap-fill exercise in Part 2.

PART 1 — VOCABULARY TABLE

WORD / PHRASE	DEFINITION	EXAMPLE SENTENCE
semaglutide	the active ingredient in Ozempic and Wegovy; a drug that mimics the gut hormone GLP-1 to suppress appetite and regulate blood sugar	<i>Semaglutide was possibly the most talked-about medicine of 2023, originally developed to treat type 2 diabetes.</i>
GLP-1	glucagon-like peptide-1; a gut hormone released after eating that makes us feel full and stimulates insulin production	<i>GLP-1 is normally pumped out by the body after eating; semaglutide works by mimicking its action.</i>
GIP	glucose-dependent insulinotropic polypeptide; a second gut hormone that, like GLP-1, helps regulate blood sugar and appetite	<i>Tirzepatide works by mimicking not only GLP-1 but also a second gut hormone called GIP.</i>
tirzepatide	the active ingredient in Zepbound; a dual-hormone drug that mimics both GLP-1 and GIP	<i>Tirzepatide helped people lose 21 per cent of their body weight in trials, compared with 15 per cent for semaglutide.</i>
mimicking	imitating or reproducing the action of something natural, such as a hormone, using a synthetic compound	<i>These drugs work by mimicking hormones that are naturally released by the body after eating.</i>
insulin	a hormone produced by the pancreas that regulates blood sugar levels by helping cells absorb glucose	<i>GLP-1 boosts the release of insulin, helping to regulate blood sugar in people with or without diabetes.</i>
placebo	an inactive substance given to a control group in a clinical trial to test the true effect of a drug	<i>Separate studies comparing both drugs with a placebo suggest that tirzepatide could be superior.</i>
head-to-head trials	clinical trials that directly compare two active treatments against each other rather than against a placebo	<i>Zepbound and Wegovy have not yet been compared in head-to-head trials — only in separate placebo studies.</i>

WORD / PHRASE	DEFINITION	EXAMPLE SENTENCE
analogue	a synthetic compound that has a similar structure and function to a naturally occurring substance	<i>One new injection contains both semaglutide and an analogue of amylin — a hormone produced by the pancreas.</i>
glucagon	a hormone produced by the pancreas that raises blood sugar levels; now being explored in combination weight-loss drugs	<i>One experimental drug mimics three hormones at once — GLP-1, GIP and glucagon — earning it the nickname 'triple G'.</i>
amylin	a hormone produced by the pancreas alongside insulin; it slows digestion and reduces appetite	<i>An injection combining semaglutide with an amylin analogue is among the next generation of obesity treatments in development.</i>
PYY	peptide YY; a gut hormone released after eating that reduces appetite and slows digestion	<i>PYY is one of several hormones — alongside glucagon and amylin — being explored in next-generation obesity drugs.</i>
oral formulation	a version of a medicine designed to be swallowed rather than injected	<i>Final-stage trial results are due for an oral formulation of Wegovy for those without diabetes.</i>
self-injectable	a medication designed to be administered by the patient themselves using an injection device	<i>Ozempic is sold as a self-injectable drug — patients administer it themselves, typically once a week.</i>
pipeline	here: the range of drugs that are currently in development and have not yet been approved for use	<i>The article previews a smorgasbord of treatments in the pipeline that could reach patients in 2024 and beyond.</i>
supply shortages	a situation in which demand for a product exceeds the available supply	<i>As Novo Nordisk couldn't keep up with demand, supply shortages of semaglutide spread across the US.</i>
employer-based insurance	health insurance provided by a person's employer rather than purchased individually or provided by the government	<i>The number of employer-based insurance providers planning to cover weight-loss drugs is rising sharply.</i>
access	here: the ability of patients to obtain and afford medical treatments	<i>Drucker hopes that more medicines on the market will translate into improved access and less expensive treatments.</i>
potent	having a strong, powerful effect; more potent drugs produce greater results at lower doses	<i>A more potent fat-busting injection will probably enter clinics in 2024, capable of greater weight loss.</i>
smorgasbord	a wide and varied selection of things; from the Swedish word for a buffet-style spread	<i>The article promises a smorgasbord of new obesity treatments to look forward to in 2024 and beyond.</i>
glut	an excessively large supply or amount of something, often causing problems	<i>Supply shortages of semaglutide sparked a glut of headlines in 2023 as patients and doctors scrambled for alternatives.</i>

WORD / PHRASE	DEFINITION	EXAMPLE SENTENCE
on the horizon	expected to happen or become available in the near future	<i>More effective weight-loss drugs are on the horizon, including those that mimic three hormones simultaneously.</i>
double helpings	informal: twice as much of something; here used humorously to mean even more coverage than before	<i>The article opens by warning readers to 'get ready for double helpings' of weight-loss drug stories in 2024.</i>

PART 2 — GAP-FILL EXERCISE

Complete the sentences using the correct word or phrase from the word bank below. You may need to change the form of the word. Most sentences require more than one answer. Pay close attention to the article's argument — students who have read carefully will have a clear advantage.

WORD BANK

semaglutide	GLP-1	GIP	tirzepatide
mimicking	insulin	placebo	head-to-head trials
analogue	glucagon	amylin	PYY
oral formulation	self-injectable	pipeline	supply shortages
employer-based insurance	access	potent	smorgasbord
glut	on the horizon	double helpings	

1	_____ works by _____ the action of _____, a gut hormone normally released after eating, which makes us feel full, reduces appetite, and boosts the release of _____ to regulate blood sugar.
2	Unlike semaglutide, _____ targets not one but two gut hormones — _____ and _____ — making it potentially more effective, based on separate studies comparing both drugs against a _____.
3	Although the two leading drugs have not yet been compared in _____, the studies available suggest tirzepatide may be _____, helping patients lose 21% of body weight versus 15%.
4	The _____ for next-generation obesity treatments includes drugs that mimic _____, _____, and _____ — and one triple combination nicknamed 'triple G' that targets all three simultaneously.
5	One experimental treatment combines semaglutide with an _____ of _____, a hormone produced by the pancreas alongside insulin that slows digestion and suppresses appetite.
6	Another gut hormone being studied as a drug target is _____, while _____ — produced by the pancreas — is also being explored in combination treatments alongside GLP-1 and GIP.

7	_____ of semaglutide across the US led to delayed launches in other markets, generating a _____ of media coverage in 2023 as patients competed for limited supplies.
8	One barrier to widespread use has been the reluctance of US health insurers to fund these drugs, but _____ providers covering this class of medicine are set to rise from 25% to 43% in 2024.
9	Drucker hopes that more medicines in the _____ will translate into more competition, better _____ for patients, and ultimately less expensive treatments across the board.
10	Some patients would prefer a pill to a weekly injection, and final-stage trials are underway for an _____ of Wegovy — a _____ version of the drug that patients could simply swallow.
11	More _____ treatments are clearly _____ — the drugs are, as Drucker puts it, 'getting more powerful', with a new generation of therapies expected to deliver even greater weight loss.
12	The article opens with a food metaphor — promising a _____ of new treatments and warning readers to get ready for _____ of weight-loss drug stories — reflecting just how rapidly this field is developing.

Write your answers here:

1. _____	2. _____	3. _____
4. _____	5. _____	6. _____
7. _____	8. _____	9. _____
10. _____	11. _____	12. _____